



Maritime &
Coastguard
Agency

Guidance

MGN 691 (M) New Training Requirements for Use of Electronic Chart Systems and Radar on UK registered Workboats and Pilot Boats

Updated 16 May 2024

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Summary

This MGN notifies all personnel involved with the operation or certifying of UK registered commercially operating small vessels, or training or crewing of personnel on UK registered commercially operating small vessels, of new mandatory requirements to undertake MCA approved or recognised training in the use of Electronic Chart Systems and Radar. This MGN provides details of new training options, the applicability of training to existing personnel, the requirements for training of new personnel, and the deadlines for which training should be completed.

1. Introduction/background

1.1 In 2018, mandatory training requirements were introduced for Masters and crew working onboard UK registered Workboats and Pilot Boats certificated under Workboat Code Edition 2 to complete training in Electronic Chart Systems, and Radar (where installed) by 31 December 2021.

1.2 Workboat Code Edition 3 introduces further requirements for training in Electronic Chart Systems and Radar to be MCA approved or recognised.

1.3 To coincide with the entry into force of Workboat Code Edition 3 on 13 December 2023, the MCA has updated and developed the MCA Small Ships Navigation and Radar course to provide a tailored training solution that meets the needs and requirements of the small commercial vessel industry. The development of this course introduces changes to the syllabus and structure that reflect technological developments of Electronic Chart Systems; reflect the use of radar within the sector; and provide greater flexibility to operators and personnel through a modular split of the topics covered by the course.

1.4 From 13 December 2023, Masters and any member of crew involved in or responsible for navigation on a UK registered small commercial vessel certified to Workboat Code Edition 3, and/or using radar on UK registered small commercial vessels certified to Workboat Code Edition 3, must undertake the relevant modules of an MCA approved Small Ships Navigation and Radar course.

1.5 Section 2 of this MGN provides details of the changes to the structure of the MCA Small Ships Navigation and Radar course and lists the training modules a candidate shall undertake in navigation and/or radar.

1.6 Section 3 provides details of appropriate training in Electronic Chart Systems.

1.7 Section 4 provides details of appropriate training in Radar.

1.8 Section 5 provides details of accepted alternative qualifications in place of Electronic Chart Systems and Radar training.

1.9 Section 6 provides details of transitional arrangements in place for Masters and crew that completed a course of training accepted under Workboat Code Edition 2.

1.10 Crew, other than Masters, working on UK registered Small Commercial Vessels that do not operate radar and do not have responsibility for, or involvement in, the navigation of the vessel do not need to undertake further training in navigation and radar and will not need to complete the MCA approved or recognised training course listed in this MGN.

2. Course Structure: Training Modules

2.1 MCA Small Ships Navigation and Radar has been split into two, independently deliverable, modules to provide greater flexibility to meet

the training needs of Masters and crew working on UK registered small commercial vessels. This course now comprises the following two training modules:

1: Small Ships Electronic Charting Systems (approved) and Bridge Watchkeeping (20 hours); and

2: Small Ships Radar & Meteorology (16 hours)

2.2 As owners and operators move toward paperless navigation, with some already fulfilling the requirements by use of ECDIS or Mini-ECDIS, the Small Ships Electronic Charting Systems (approved) and Bridge Watchkeeping module focusses on the features and functions of approved ECS, official electronic charts (ENCs), and electronic navigation techniques as detailed in MGN 319 or appropriate ECDIS regulations.

This course module has been formulated to teach safe paperless navigation in anticipation of greater uptake of this practice but recognises that paper navigation still takes place for those vessels who remain using paper charts as primary means of navigation with electronic systems to supplement their operations. Completion of this module will ensure suitable qualification of personnel working on small vessels to use approved ECS, as well as provide training to those whose vessels are fitted with ECDIS as an aid to navigation, rather than primary means of navigation.

2.3 Training centres approved to deliver the November 2023 revision of the MCA Small Ships Navigation and Radar course are now permitted and able to deliver the two modules independently, as well as to deliver a full 36-hour course that incorporates both modules. A list of MCA approved training providers can be found by searching “MCA approved training providers (ATP)” on www.gov.uk (<http://www.gov.uk>).

2.4. Details on the applicability of the Small Ships Electronic Charting Systems (approved) and Bridge Watchkeeping (20 hours) module to Masters’ or crew members’ training needs can be found in Section 3 of this MGN.

2.5. Details on the applicability of the Small Ships Radar & Meteorology (16 hours) module to Masters’ or crew members’ training needs can be found in Section 4 of this MGN.

2.6 Guidance for training centres seeking approval to deliver an MCA approved training course can be found in MSN 1865, as amended.

3. Training Requirements for Use of Electronic Chart Systems

3.1 All Masters, and all Crew responsible for navigation, working onboard a vessel certified under Workboat Code Edition 3 that have not undertaken MCA approved or recognised training (see 3.3), are required to undertake the Small Ships Electronic Charting Systems (approved) and Bridge Watchkeeping (20 hours) module of an MCA approved Small Ships Navigation and Radar course within 12 months of the publication of this MGN.

3.2 Crew members, other than the Master, that are not responsible or involved in the navigation of the vessel are not required to complete this training.

3.3 Masters or crew holding a UK Certificate of Competency (UK CoC) or approved training listed under Section 5 of this MGN, or that qualify under the transitional arrangements listed under Section 6 of this MGN are considered to have met the training requirements for UK registered Small Commercial Vessels and do not need to complete the training specified in 3.1 above.

4. Training Requirements for Use of Radar

4.1 All Masters on board vessels that are certified under Workboat Code Edition 3 equipped with Radar, that have not undertaken MCA approved or recognised training (see 4.4) are required to undertake the Small Ships Radar & Meteorology (16 hours) module of an MCA approved Small Ships Navigation and Radar course within 12 months of the publication of this MGN.

4.2 All Crew working on board vessels that are certified under Workboat Code Edition 3 equipped with radar, that are likely to use radar, that have not undertaken MCA approved or recognised training (see 4.4) are required to undertake the Small Ships Radar & Meteorology (16 hours) module of an MCA approved Small Ships Navigation and Radar course within 12 months of the publication of this MGN.

4.3 Crew members, other than the Master, that do not and are not likely to operate the Radar are not required to complete this training.

4.4 Masters or crew holding a UK CoC or approved training listed under Section 5 of this MGN, or that qualify under the transitional arrangements listed under Section 6 of this MGN are considered to have met the training requirements for UK registered Small Commercial Vessels and do not need to complete the training specified in 4.1 above.

5. Accepted Alternative Qualifications

5.1 Masters and crew holding the following UK issued Certificates of Competency (UK CoC) or higher are not required to complete the training specified under Section 3 or Section 4 of this MGN as holders of these certificates have completed a course of training leading to the issue of a UK CoC that meets the training requirements for UK registered Small Commercial Vessels certified under Workboat Code Edition 3:

- OOW unlimited STCW II/1 or
- Master/OOW Less than 500GT Near Coastal STCW II/3 CoC
- OOW Less than 500GT Tug Near Coastal STCW II/3 CoC
- UK Class 1 or 2 Fishing CoC
- OOW Yacht <3000 GT STCW II/1 CoC

5.2 Masters and crew holding the following MCA course completion certificates are not required to complete the training in Section 3 or Section 4 of this MGN as completion of these courses are considered to meet the training requirements for UK registered Small Commercial Vessels certified under Workboat Code Edition 3:

- MCA approved Navigation Aids and Equipment Simulator Training (NAEST) Operational Certificate, or
- MCA approved Navigation and Radar (OOW or Master) Yachts Pass Certificate, or
- Any training certificate listed in MIN 698 relevant to the training requirements of navigation and radar added at a future date following publication of this MGN.

6. Transitional Arrangements for the Implementation of Workboat Code 3.

6.1 Following the publication of Workboat Code Edition 3, all existing vessels^[footnote 1] that are UK registered workboats or pilot boats certificated under Brown Code, MGN 280 or Workboat Code Edition 2 are required to certify under Workboat Code Edition 3 at their next renewal examination. Once an existing vessel has renewed certification under Workboat Code Edition 3, all Masters and crew to which training is required must complete training in accordance with this MGN within the time period specified under Appendix 9, paragraph 3 of Workboat Code Edition 3, i.e at the vessel's renewal examination to Workboat Code 3 or three years after the date of entry into force of the Code, whichever is later, unless Section 5 or the following paragraphs of Section 6 of this MGN apply.

6.2 Masters and crew that have completed training in Navigation and Radar, as per the requirements of Section 2.11 and Section 2.13 of Appendix 3 of Workboat Code Edition 2 will be considered to have met the training requirements of Workboat Code Edition 3 providing the training was undertaken at a date prior to the publication of this MGN.

6.3 Masters and crew that can demonstrate evidence^[footnote 2] of a booking to attend a training course as required by Workboat Code Edition 2, against navigation, radar, or both at a date prior to the publication of this MGN, will be accepted as having met the training requirements for Navigation and/or Radar on UK registered Workboats and Pilot Boats certificated under Workboat Code Edition 3 on successful completion of that course before 31 May 2024.

6.4 Where a Master or member of crew has not yet completed training in Electronic Chart Systems or Radar and cannot meet 6.2 or 6.3 above, but are serving or due to serve in a capacity responsible for navigation and/or radar on board a UK registered workboat or pilot boat that is currently certificated under Workboat Code Edition 2 or earlier, they are strongly recommended to complete training in accordance with this MGN to prevent the need to recomplete training as vessels migrate to Workboat Code Edition 3.

More information

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Website: www.gov.uk/mca (<https://www.gov.uk/mca>)

1. “Existing vessel” means a vessel which does not meet the definition of a “new vessel” under Workboat Code Edition 3.
2. Submission to the Administration of an email booking confirmation or letter demonstrating that the course was booked and paid for at a date prior to this MGN publication, as well as a course completion certificate indication successful completion of the course before 31 May 2024 will be accepted as meeting the Navigation and Radar requirements for UK registered small commercial vessels certified to Workboat Code Edition 3.



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